

The Three Dev of Hrom

The children are looking at him with great anticipation, but he pretends to be hesitant. Actually, he is. The story he has planned for today, it's called the Three Dev (Demons) of Rome, but they are actually his own demons he is about to confront. Lately, they have resurfaced again in his nightmares. It might have to do with daddy having left for the east. He wanted to come too, but his own stories have been his undoing: *Shāhān-Shāh* Husrow is so pleased with his storytelling, entertaining his children, that he has requested him to stay in Tisfon. And so, parentless, his dreams of terror have returned. But as they say, you have to face your own demons. And this story is supposed to do this.

—"Come on, Varaz, tell us! Of the Princess and her Knight!"

Āzar pulls on his sleeve, while her older brother has to of course make his usual sarcastic remarks.

—"He doesn't know any story anymore, Āzar."

—"No, Shirowe, he does," turning with her big eyes to him again, "right, Varaz?"

—"Of course I do. It is just ... it's so scary and gruesome, that I am not sure whether. . .," he glances at the *Bāmbishn*, who as ever remains stoic, "what if it scares little Shasha. And what about you, girls, I don't want you to have nightmares."

—"Oh, come on, Varaz, we can handle it. Right auntie, Shasha can listen too, no?"

The slight nod of Shasha's mother makes them all cheer. In fact, of all the members of his audience, he is the most apprehensive of the *Bāmbishn*. How much would she be able to figure out this time? Queens, in general, always can see straight through him. But the *Bāmbishn*, she is a whole other level! Except, there is actually nothing to hide this time—all his secrets have already been revealed—he has been no match for the niftiness of the Queens.

—"Okay, okay. I will tell. But do not come complain to me afterwards. I warn you, this is not for the faint-hearted."

—"You hear that, Āzar, perhaps you should leave."

—"Shut up, Shirowe, we all stay!"

Meanwhile, Abrangih also has joined them, that sneaky little devil! One day he is going to get hold of her and make her tell. It is also clear that the

Queens know more about the girl than they let on. But on to the story!
—“Alright then.”

SO, what never was supposed to happen, happened! Evil Gennadius’s most vile plan worked and our two heroes.... Oh, by all the saints, what evil has befallen them! This might very well be the end for our brave duo! *Āy wāy!* ❧

—“Oh no, what happened?”

She can hear the trepidation in her sister’s voice. Could this really be the end of the Princess and the Knight? Perhaps they should not have insisted on telling the story. Āzar always gets too much involved.

WELL, it all started with the Princess of Maurestān. Oh, she was such a lovely girl, cheerful and happy, pretty as a *nymfe*... ❧

—“What is a *nymfe*, Varaz?”

—“Oh, it’s like ... a beautiful young girl.”

—“What’s her name?”

Why do they always want a name? So, he picks the first that comes to mind.

—“Fabia!”

He only had met the girl once—she must have been at least five years older than him. Daddy had introduced her and her father Rogatus, and afterwards daddy had asked what he thought of her. Well, she was pretty, but nothing like his princess. In fact, as far as he remembers she is not even a princess. Her father is some rich landlord, whom daddy had done business with, but that was a little too mundane for this story. So, overnight, plain Fabia has turned princess, ha, ha

AND her father was the King of Maurestān. But evil Gennadius covets the kingdom of her father, and so, he comes with a big army of Mauri [Moors]. But King Rogatus and his daughter, they are *Hromāyig* [Roman]. And so, when evil Gennadius kills her father, he commands her:

~“Princess Fabia, you shall be my wife, and together we will rule the whole of Afrika.” But she replies

~“Never will I marry the murderer of my father. I rather die myself and be with my father in Heaven.” *Āy wāy*, with these words, did she seal her fate!? ❧

Oh, no, now also princess Fabia is going to die? Perhaps this is not going to be such a good story. She looks at her sister, but she seems oddly unfazed by these developments. She is right of course: in Varaz's tales, the princesses in the end always win. Her sister once had told her

~"You know why I know that the princesses always are going to win, Borān? Because they look out for each other! Like us, sisters! We will always help each other. Like grandmama tells us to, remember!" Yeah, she has to trust in the supremacy of the princesses.

—"Did she ... follow her father, Varaz?"

WELL, when evil Gennadius sees that she does not answer his advances, he gets very angry and wants to hang her from the highest tree. But then Gennadius comes up with an even more devious plan.

~"I will tie her up and put her on the tallest tower I can find, so that the whole world can see that she is my captive. And then, that insolent Princess and her guileful Knight will see her too, and *ewār* [surely], they will want to come to her rescue, but my men will be waiting for them and they will capture them, har, har, har!" And so he went to look for the tallest tower in the world. ♣

—"Oh, I know, Varaz. The Tower in *Bābel*, remember, the one evil Shami-ram built."

—"Ah, yeah! But no. The Tower of Arrogance, that one has crumbled down—vanity only lasts that long. No, there is another one that suits his purposes: the *faros* of Alexandria!"

—"What is a *faros*, Varaz?"

—"It means a light house containing an ever burning fire."

—"Like a Fire Temple?"

—"No, no, it is for ships in the night, to know where the coast is, that they don't sail into the rocks. And the one in Alexandria, it is the tallest one anyone has ever seen, unfathomably many fathoms high."

—"Have you seen it, Varaz, how high it is?"

—"Me? But I am just a simple storyteller, Borān, not a peripatetic pataphysicist," he has been waiting for ever to use that expression. Master Pahrabad and him had come up with the term. And they had laughed so hard: for it has no meaning, other than being meaningless, ha, ha, "So, I am guessing quite high."

—“Sostratos of Knidos built it at a height trice that of the present residence,” it takes her a while to figure out that auntie means the palace they’re in now. Wow, that’s high. If you stand in front of the *aywān* [hall] and look up, you almost fall over. Imagine doing that three times, “on top of which a furnace is lit every night, while during the day, a mirror reflects the sun, to show passage for ships and to foretell the fords and the entrance to the harbor.”¹

—“Well, now you know how high, children. We always learn something new, don’t we? Don’t forget our motto:

*Where wondrous facts
would wistfully flail
with wisecracking fiction,
will wonderment not fail.*

But let’s get back to the denouement of our story.”

And so, when poor Fabia is bound on a stake they have erected on top of the *faros*, the whole world can see her plight. And the Princess and her Knight, of course they see it too, and they know it must be the devilry of evil Gennadius.

~“Oh, my knight, look what evil Gennadius has done to the poor Princess of Maurestān! We must help her!”

~“My princess, why would vile Gennadius announce his mischief so publicly? I fear that it is a trap.”

~“*Alā*, when you know it is a trap, it no longer is, right?” And so, of course, the intrepid duo has to come to the rescue of the princess. As they climb the thousand steps, they are on the look out for Gennadius’ men, yet they don’t see any. What is up with that? 🍷

—“Oh, no, Varaz, they are going to be captured!”

Is that then their fate? *Alā*, when they reach the summit, they find an exhausted Fabia, at the brink of unconsciousness. But when they want to untie her, with a raspy voice, with her last breath, Fabia exclaims

~“Not the ropes! Not the ropes!” The Princess and her Knight look puzzled at each other. What does she mean? But

¹Pliny, 36.83.

it is too late, they are already untying the hundred knots. But what is happening? Their eyelids start to feel so heavy, their heads start to bob, and their legs, why are they so wobbly? ❧

—“Oh, no! A poison! Evil Gennadius poisoned the ropes!”

—“Indeed, Āzar. In his wicked scheme, he has doused the ropes with a sleeping potion, so potent that whomever touches it, falls immediately in a deep slumber!”

—“They have to take the antidote, Varaz! Remember, the one they learned from the *Silver Book of Cantations*.”

That was clever thinking of her friend.

—“Yeah, Varaz, as Abrangih said, quick, the antidote!”

He forgot about that *deus-ex machina*, but they still have to live through their ordeal. And thus...

THE Princess, lifts her arm to say the incantation: awake... the wo...ke, wa...ken the wea...wa...woo—ooh, how soft that cushion is, I just wanna put my head on it, and... ❧

He pretends to fall asleep, but then veers up.

OH, no, children, before she could utter the counterspell, our beauty is sleeping! And when she and the Knight wake up many hours later, they find themselves in the dungeons of Hrom [Rome], amidst the pungent smell of wild beasts and rotting flesh. Evil Gennadius has bound the Knight's right hand behind his back and a blindfold over his eyes. And of the Princess, he has bound her left arm behind her back and a gag over her mouth. For he knows that the Knight's sword arm is his right arm, while with her left arm, the Princess will weave her magic and with her mouth cast her spells. And so, he truly has bound their powers! *Āy wāy*, they have become helpless. And they are also still groggy from the sleeping potion. And so, evil Gennadius tells them what fate awaits them.

~“For the whole world to see, how you, insolent princess, and your brazen knight, will perish under the justice of the Law of the *Augustus*.” So, children, is the *Augustus* going to kill them? ❧

—“Who is *Augustus*, Varaz?”

—“The Emperor, you nitwit! Are you not paying attention in class.”
Ooh, that is so unfair! That Shirowe always picks on her little sister. She is only seven! How can she know—and she has to confess that she didn’t know either. She shoots her darkest glances at him, but he just makes a grimace.

Indeed, the Emperor of Hrom himself has agreed to Gennadius’s wicked scheme, that the Princess and her valiant Knight are to be thrown into the *Hippódromos*, where they will have to face. . . ♣

He pauses to emphasize the gravity of the situation—and now to the part where he, together with his hero, will face his demons.

THE Three Dev of Hrom. And so, they are led into the arena, and when they enter, they are greeted by the roar of ten thousands of spectators, a sea of angry voices, for all of Hrom has come to witness the demise of the Princess and her Knight. ♣

—“But don’t they know that Gennadius is the evil one, and that the Princess and the Knight always save the poor people?!”

—“Indeed, Abrangih, so vile is Gennadius’s tongue, that he would twist all of their heroic exploits into tales of sedition. He tells them how. . .”
He changes his voice’s pitch to imitate the evilness of the governor.

THE Princess and the Knight offered the Captain as a human sacrifice to the Lion Queen of Sheba. ♣

—“That was what happened, right?”

—“No, Varaz! The opposite is true: they saved the Captain from the Square Lion, remember!”

—“And did they then not. . .”

OF jealousy and spite, they brought the proud citizens of *Bābel* to tears, and razed their city to the ground? ♣

—“No, Varaz, they saved the people from Queen Shamiram, remember, she had made them their slaves!”

BUT they surely stuffed their bellies with the sweet flesh of Younā the Whale! ♣

—“They went into Younā’s belly, silly.”
He shakes his head.

—“If only you were there, children. You could have averted this cruel fate awaiting our heroes!”

BUT as there is no one to defend their honor, the people are duped by Gennadius’s rhetoric and they now demand justice. How little do they know that they are about to witness the greatest deed of injustice! *Āy wāy! Āy wāy!* ❧

Another long pause, making them all squirm on their cushion, but he needs to compose himself, overwhelmed by the memory of waves of *Prasinous* [Green] and *Benetous* [Blue] supporters, chanting for his family’s death.

AND then they can hear a roar even more frightening, making the hairs in your neck stand up. For the *Augustus* has given the signal to release the three Dev. And the first one comes out of its cage.

~“My princess, what do you see?” an anxious Knight asks. But perhaps it is for the better that she is gagged, so that she cannot tell her Knight the terrifying sight of a monstrous bear twice their size. Oh no, look at its claws, they are three times that of an eagle. Oh, children, don’t look at his hairy pelt, still covered in the blood of its helpless victims. And what about the thousand angry wasps circling his head. Perhaps it is for the better that the brave Knight cannot see its bloodshot eyes, for there is only death in them, for this is the demon *Melivorus Maximus*. And then they release the second Dev, *Mithrothragna*, and the crowd gasps loudly at the horrific sight of that gigantic bull, foaming furiously from its mouth. *Āy wāy*, the horror! On its horns the limbs of his former victims are still impaled. *Pad Yazdān*, scorpions are crawling all over his body. And, children, dare I say it: its balls are as big as my head... ❧

He can hear the girls giggle between their hands, clasped over their eyes, as if the Dev are really in the room. It also seems to have piqued the imagination of his detractor, Shirowe.

—“And the third one?”

—“Oh, dear, I was really hoping it would not be him!”

For it is the most horrid creature ever to roam the earth. It is ... the demon *Andropodalis*, in the shape of a ferocious lion with the legs of a giant. From its manes, hissing serpents are emanating. His fangs could perforate the trunk of a tree. His maw could—with his hands, he imitates two jaws, pretending to grab little Abrangih, making the girl shriek—swallow a boar. How are the Princess and her Knight ever going to defeat these Dev? Their powers curtailed, their minds numbed by Gennadius's potion. How will they get out of this one? But perhaps, I should not tell you the rest of the tale. Perhaps it is better I don't. . . 🐉

He pauses. Textbook storytelling: aposiopesis to cause a mini-insurrection.

—“We need to know, Varaz. You can't stop now!”

—“Come on, Varaz, please continue!”

—“Yeah, will justice prevail?”

Of course, uttered with his usual sarcasm, but even he, Shirowe, seems to be engrossed by the story. A captive audience as reimbursement for his family's captivity, ha, ha.

—“Okay, okay, I will tell.”

So, as the three Dev are approaching them, *Melivorus Maximus*, *Mithrothragna*, and *Andropodalis*, belching their fiery breaths, the Princess and her Knight hold each other's hand. ~“What are we to do, my princess, now that evil Gennadius has reduced us both to half of who we are,” but then the Knight has this ingenious idea, “But don't they say that two halves make a whole. Hurry, let's swap places. And then you interlock your left arm with my right, both bound behind our backs, so that two halves become one, and with your right hand you will wield my sword, and with my left, I will conjure your magic, and my thoughts will be yours and your thoughts will be mine, and my words will be yours and your words will be mine, and my deeds will be yours and your deeds will be mine. For we are one, Princess and Knight together, and as one, we can defeat those vile Dev!” And so, united, she tells him in his mind: ~“We need the high ground! Let's run to the *spina*!” Do you

guys know what that is? 🐝

—“Yeah, remember Borān, when mom Mariam takes us to the chariot races. She told us, in the middle, that’s the *spina*, and the horsies have to go around it.”

—“Very good, Āzar.”

SO, to the *spina* they run, two as one, and they stand with their backs against the base of the great obelisk. . . 🐝

—“What’s an obelisk, Varaz?”

—“Oh, right. You don’t have those here.”

IT’s like a great column, but it is hewn from one single rock and it is mightily tall, fifteen fathom high! And it is so heavy that no humans have ever lifted it up. And on its base, there are carved hundreds of little figurines, enraptured by the scene of bravery and defiance of our heroic duo, readying themselves against those three wicked Dev. For now that the Princess’s hand wields the Knight’s sword, and the Knight’s mouth weaves curses upon the Dev’s heads, now that the Knight can see with the Princess’s eyes their weakest spots and the Princess can fling bolts of lightning and fire with the Knight’s arm, they are ready to face their demons. With the Knight’s sword, she cuts the legs of the bear *Melivorus Maximus*, making him roll helplessly on the floor, and with the Princess’s fire, he chases away the angry wasps. . . 🐝

—“Hee, hee, Varaz, you’re saying it wrong again. It’s *waps*!”

If you’d ask him, it’s the Persians who got it wrong, for the Romans also say *vespa*/wasp. But when in Persia, do as the Persians, ha, ha. Although, technically, the story plays in Rome.

OH, right, angry *waps*! But that was just the first Dev. Next, the raging bull *Mithrothragna* comes stampeding towards them. But now being one of mind, in an incredible demonstration of bravery, they seize its horns, and shouting such a powerful malediction, they wrench its neck and crush both horns,² and they grab his tail and rip off one of its hooves, leaving the demon helplessly limping around. But this enrages the third demon, the lion *Andropodalis*, still

²Sebeos, 10.58.

shackled, bellowing in anger. And with his giant feet, he stamps so hard on the ground, that it makes the entire stadium shake and people start yelling in fear. For the crowd now realizes that not the valiant Princess and Knight are the evildoers, but wicked Gennadius. And so now they turn their pleading chants to the *Augustus*.

~“Oh wise and benevolent *Augustus*, let these heroes live. Do not send the lion *Andropodalis* unto them!” But Gennadius, who sits next to the *Augustus* in the royal *Káthisma*... 🐉

—“Oh, I know, that is the loge from which we watch the games in Weh-Andiyok-Husrow, right, Borān? Mom Mariam told us.”

—“Indeed, Āzar”

High above the stands, in the imperial *Káthisma*, the *Augustus* and his family are watching the games. And then empress Konstantina... 🐉

Oops, a slip of the tongue: being carried away by his story, he incorporated the true empress, but luckily Borān is so engrossed in the tale that the mention of her grandaunt goes unnoticed—he glances at her brother—yep, telling from his look, Shirowe did register the name: one of his many illustrious ancestors, as he always would call them—but he doesn’t say anything either

IMean, the Empress, she implores her husband
~“My dear husband, stop this perversity, I beg of You.”
But wicked Gennadius whispers in the *Augustus*’s ears
~“You commanded them to be tried by ordeal, Your Majesty. You cannot retract Your word. Only if they can also survive the fiery ire of the lion *Andropodalis*,” you know, Gennadius is so sure that they will not survive the clutches of *Andropodalis*, for no one has ever fought the lion demon and lived to tell, “You can show Your mercy.” And so the *Augustus*, duped by Gennadius’s lies, gives the signal to release the third Dev. The crowd gasps: *Andropodalis* attacks, the earth trembling under its giant feet. Will this be their demise? Through the Princess’s eyes, he can see the beast storm towards them and his heart skips a beat. And through the Knight’s mouth, she adjures

~“IESOUS! MARIAM! IOSEF!!” Perhaps they should take shelter behind the obelisk. But with his giant legs, the lion *Andropodalis* would turn around and assault them again and again and again. No, they have to fight the lion facing it head on. And so they brace themselves, steadying themselves for an act of utmost bravery. And then..., the lion *Andropodalis* leaps forward. But to the astonishment of the entire crowd, the two that now have become one, in hypostatic union, the Princess and the Knight, they grab the lion demon by the ear and jump astride it, and seizing the throat, they choke and kill the beast. And then the clamor of the vast mob fills the place,³ as the people are rejoicing in the heroic feats of our intrepid duo. And they chant

~“Clemency for the heroes! Out with the bones of Gennadius!” And so, against all odds, against anyone’s expectation, the Princess and the Knight triumph over evil Gennadius. They are safe, children! They are safe! 🕊️

It all is getting too much, and he sits down, as tears well up in his eyes and he covers his face.

—“Varaz, are you crying?”

It suddenly hits him why these dark events from his boyhood have again resurfaced. While the actual terror has subsided, only emerging in his dreams, he still vividly remembers the great relief afterwards, that they were still alive, that daddy had won, that the emperor had forgiven them. He even vaguely remembers the old lady with the red hair, Borān’s great grandmother, who caressed him. But that moment of exhilaration and relief, that had been the true lie. That had been the great deceit! For afterwards, on their voyage to their exile in North-Africa, the real horror had happened, it was then that the black abyss had opened and the demon had swallowed him. He has to gasp for air, barely able to contain himself from crying out loud: mommy!! That’s the horror that had happened; too weakened by their ordeal, mommy had succumbed to only-God-knows what disease.

And now, daddy is in the east and he is all alone here! But he has a sacred duty now: to serve at the pleasure of the *Shāhān-Shāh*, to entertain his children with his riveting tales. And sorrow has no place in these tales.

³Sebeos, 10.58.

So, he composes himself and looks at Āzar.

—“Tears of joy, Āzar. Tears of joy! If those two would not have made it, I would be out of a job. No more stories about the beautiful Princess and her valiant Knight. Imagine what calamity that would be! But luckily, the tale goes on. And even better, the *Augustus* throws evil Gennadius in the dungeons and appoints a new governor of Afrika.”

—“Yay!!”

What about that poor princess who lost her father and her home?

—“Varaz, what happened to princess Fabia?”

—“*Alā*, a very good question, Borān. Could it be that she will fall in love with the son of the new governor,” daddy had told him that after Gennadius had retired from his post, apparently a fellow countryman, an Armenian, had been granted the office of governor, if he remembered correctly, one Heraklios, “But that’s a tale for later, children.”

—“Aww!”

—“Varaz,” as per his usual, Shirowe is going to try to debunk his story—oddly enough, although he doesn’t like the boy that much, this verbal sparring he actually looks forward to, “were you fooling us when you said that no human can lift the obelisk. How did it then get there?”

Triumph gleams in his eyes while he looks at the others. Alright, here comes the parry!

—“Ah, a very good question, dear Shirowe, the enigma that is gravity. For some things are too heavy too lift, and some things are too light to lift.”

—“Ha, ha, Varaz, that’s not possible. If it is light, you can lift it. Look,” Āzar pulls the cushion from underneath her and holds it above her head, “I am lifting it!”

—“And still I stand by what I say. And if you do not believe me, I have to tell you a story, and then you will agree with me. But perhaps not today...”

—“Oh, no, Varaz, you have to tell us,” pointing to her older brother, “otherwise Shirowe is going to keep saying that you’re telling lies.”

—“Yes, pretty, pretty please.”

Who can resist those big brown eyes of little Āzar in which are reflected those of her glorious mommy, queen Shirin.

—“Alright, I will tell you the story of the Baker of Boḫārā. And then you tell me whether I was lying or not!”

—“Yay!”

SO, one day, the *Shād* [Prince] of Boḫārā decides to pay the beautiful city of Samarkand a visit. Do you guys know where those places are? 🍷

—“In the land of Turān?”

—“Those are just children’s tales, Āzar, there is no such land of Turān.”

—“Yes, there is. Where the demon come from, Māzandarān.”

—“So, which is it, Āzar, Turān or Māzandarān?”

Okay, time to interfere.

—“Well, places go by many names. Like here, you guys call this Erān, right. But the *Hromāyig* [Roman] say Persia. Which is it then? So, these cities, we now call their land Sogd, beyond the great river Wehrud [Oxus]. But coming back to my story.”

SO, when in Samarkand, as he is strolling in the bazaar, the *Shād* of Boḫārā gets a little hungry. Hmm, a bakery. A waft of freshly baked dough emanates from its door, inviting the *Shād* in. And look at that, a huge pile of flat bread, straight from the clay oven—they say that their ovens are so tall that a man can stand in it. And when he tries one of them, he exclaims

~“By the soul of my forefathers, this is the best bread I have ever eaten. I would like to eat this delicious bread every day,” turning to the baker gleaming with pride, “Good man, do you want to become my royal baker, at my palace in Boḫārā?” The baker is of course ecstatic, for it is a great honor to be the personal baker of the *Shād* of Boḫārā, and so he happily agrees. When they arrive back in Boḫārā, the baker prepares his best bread for his new master. And he brings it to the *Shād* on his golden throne. Bowing reverently, holding the piece of loaf in his outstretched hands, he says

~“Oh, great *Shād* of Boḫārā, accept this bread from Your humble *bandag* [servant].” In great anticipation, the *Shād* takes a big bite.

~“Hmm, very nice. But dear baker, the one you made for me in Samarkand tasted even better. How come?”

~“Oh, Your Majesty, methinks it is the flour. You know, the flour of Samarkand is the best.”

~“Well, than I shall forthwith send one of my pages to go

buy three bushels of flour from the bazaar in Samarkand!" And so, after a few weeks, when the page returns with the good flour, the baker sets out to make his best bread. And when it is finished, he goes to the throne room, where the *Shād* eagerly awaits him. He bows deeply in front of the *Shād*'s throne and says

~"Oh, magnificent *Shād* of Boḫārā, accept this bread from Your humbler *bandag*." But when the *Shād* takes another bite, something is still amiss.

~"Dear baker, I can tell that the flour makes it even more tasty. Yet, it is not how it was that day in your shop. What gives?"

~"Oh, Your Majesty, methinks it is the water. You know, the water of Samarkand is the purest, fresh from the mountain springs."

~"Well, than I shall forthwith send ten of my pages to go buy hundred bags of water from the bazaar in Samarkand!" And so, after a few weeks, when the ten pages return with the pure water, the baker sets out to make his best bread ever. And bowing so deep that his forehead hits the ground, he proudly offers a piece to his master, who, as always, is seated on his radiant throne, clapping his hands from excitement.

~"Oh, exalted *Shād* of Boḫārā, accept this bread from Your humblest *bandag*." But when the *Shād* takes another bite, he is still disappointed, and he jumps up from his throne.

~"Oh, accursed man. What evil witchcraft are your performing before your master. Why does your bread still not taste like the one you offered me in Samarkand?"

~"Oh, Your Majesty, calamity may befall my head, but methinks it is the air, the air of Samarkand is the freshest..." And the *Shād* of Boḫārā plops back down on his throne.

~"Thus it is this, as the calf asks the cow: why must the grass on the other side always be greener!" For even if he would send a thousand of his pages, they would never be able to carry the air of Samarkand to Boḫārā! So children, you tell me, is air then too heavy? ❧

They shake their head, as Āzar is trying to lift the air with her hands. They

all start to imitate her, giggling. He glances at Shirowe, who seems to be befuddled too. That's what he was going for, ha, ha. And before the boy realizes that he has actually not answered his original question, they are ushered out by an energetically gesticulating *darigbed* [majordomo], for dinner is to be served soon. The tale of bread has made him hungry too, so he is looking forward to supper and the company of his friend Peroz Husrow. But just as he wants to leave—no surprise there—the *Bāmbishn* calls for him; these kinds of post-narration briefings have become a standard fixture.

—“Varaz, a query. Literary references to the twin obelisk at the Circus Maximus in Hrom are rather vague. What eyewitness accounts does your description rely on? Or is yours merely extrapolation from its twin at the *Hippódromos* in Konstantinoupolis, as you yourself had observed it?”

Of course, she has figured it all out, that it was him and mommy and daddy in that arena in Konstantinoupolis, facing those wild beast.

—“Your Majesty, your observation is, as always, correct. I was describing the one in the *Hippódromos* in Konstantinoupolis,” he remembers the awe with which he had looked at it, when they had been brought in front of the cheering crowd, after daddy's victory—in his eyes, the obelisk had somehow turned into the symbol of their salvation, “but I did hear once from a merchant visiting us in Kaisareia, whose great great grandfather had seen the one in Hrom with his own eyes, when it was still standing. But after the Vandal destroyed the city, I believe it fell into ruins. But may I ask, Your Majesty, why do you call it its twin?”

—“Sources recount that both obelisks, after standing for almost two millennia on their original site at the holy city of Karnak in Agiptus, were then transported—in spite of their weight, estimated to be at least 400 ton—to the port of Alexandria under the orders of *Augustus* Dioklitianous. One was shipped [in 357] to Hrom, reportedly the tallest of the two, but the other remained in Alexandria for another 60 years, until it was finally shipped to Konstantinoupolis by *Augustus* Theodosios, standing fourteen fathom tall, the one you have seen in your moments of great duress.”

And with that, she leaves him alone to ponder about his past duress—calling it that is perhaps the road to making peace with his past.